

What else to watch: *Paths of Glory* (1957) ■ *The Pink Panther* (1963) ■ *A Clockwork Orange* (1971, p.337) ■ *Being There* (1979) ■ *The Shining* (1980, p.339) ■ *The Atomic Café* (1982) ■ *Threads* (1984)

The War Room, vast, impersonal, and punctuated by the ominous circular table with its hovering ring-shaped lighting, was designed by Ken Adam as an underground bunker.

supply with fluoridation. Ripper sends a fleet of bombers to destroy the Soviet Union, and then sits back to wait for Armageddon.

Sexual metaphors

Dr. Strangelove is a political satire, but it's also a sex comedy about the erotic relationship between men and war—the “strange love” of the title. The movie, which is subtitled *How I Learned to Stop Worrying and Love the Bomb*, opens with the romantic ballad *Try A Little Tenderness* and ends with Vera Lynn singing *We'll Meet Again* over an orgasmic montage of atomic explosions, ignited by the nuclear bomb ridden by Major “King” Kong (Slim Pickens),



which sets off the Russians' Doomsday Device. Kubrick's stark black-and-white imagery bristles with man-made erections, from nukes, gun turrets, and pistols to General Ripper's thrusting cigar.

“I do not avoid women,” he explains to the RAF's Group Captain Mandrake (Peter Sellers), blowing mushroom clouds of smoke, “but I do deny them my essence.”

This is a man's world, in which everyone gets off on mass destruction. The shadowy Dr. Strangelove (Peter Sellers again) wields a tiny cigarette, which may tell us everything we need to know about his motivations.

Formerly known as Dr. Merkwürdigliebe, Strangelove is a German émigré scientist. The models for Strangelove were Nazi rocket scientists now in the US, such as Wernher von Braun. He has a mechanical arm with a mind of its own—whenever talk turns to mass slaughter or eugenics, it rises involuntarily in a Nazi salute.

Strangelove has trouble keeping this particular erection under control, and at the prospect of the world blowing up, he jumps out of his wheelchair with a shriek of joy. “Mein Führer,” he ejaculates, »



General “Buck”

Turgidson (George C. Scott) imitates a low-flying B52 “frying chickens in a barnyard.”